

Acme — Data Retention and Deletion Policy

Effective 2024 | Privacy and Legal

1. Scope

This policy describes how Acme retains, archives, and deletes data across all business systems. It applies to customer data, employee data, financial records, operational logs, and backups. Where data is subject to specific regulations (GDPR, CCPA, HIPAA, SOX, etc.), the more restrictive of this policy or the regulation applies.

This policy does not override legal holds. When a legal hold is in effect, affected data is retained regardless of the timelines below until the hold is released by Acme Legal. Legal holds are described in section 6.

2. Customer data retention

Customer account data is retained for the active life of the account plus 24 months following account closure. Active life is defined as any 12-month period in which the customer has logged in, made a purchase, or otherwise interacted with Acme systems.

Transactional records (orders, invoices, support tickets) are retained for 7 years from the date of the transaction, in line with standard accounting and tax record-keeping requirements. This retention applies even after the customer account is closed.

Marketing preferences and consent records are retained for 3 years from the most recent consent action, unless the customer requests earlier deletion via the deletion process described in section 5.

3. Internal records

Employee records are retained for 7 years following the end of employment, in line with employment law record-keeping requirements. Recruitment records for candidates who were not hired are retained for 12 months and then deleted.

Financial records, including general ledger entries, audit trails, and supporting documentation, are retained for 10 years to satisfy SOX requirements. Acme maintains a separate immutable archive for records subject to SOX retention.

Operational logs (system access, application traces, security events) are retained for 13 months in the primary log store and a further 24 months in cold archive. Security incident logs are retained for 7 years regardless of the operational log lifecycle.

4. Backup retention

Daily backups are retained for 30 days. Weekly backups are retained for 13 weeks. Monthly backups are retained for 13 months. Acme does not maintain backups beyond 13 months for the purpose of historical recovery.

Deletion requests do not propagate to backups in real time. Data deleted in production systems is removed from backups through the normal backup lifecycle described above. This means deleted data may remain recoverable from backups for up to 13 months.

5. Data deletion requests

Customers may request deletion of their personal data through the privacy portal or by emailing privacy at acme dot com. Requests are acknowledged within 5 business days and completed within 30 days, in line with GDPR Article 17 timelines.

Deletion is not always full erasure. Data that Acme must retain to satisfy legal, financial, or contractual obligations (such as transaction records under section 2) is retained for the legally required period, but the customer's personal identifiers are pseudonymized so that the records cannot be linked back to the individual.

Deletion requests that conflict with an active legal hold are deferred until the hold is released. The customer is notified that the request has been received and queued, but is not informed of the existence or details of any legal hold.

6. Legal hold procedures

Legal holds are issued by Acme Legal in response to actual or anticipated litigation, regulatory investigation, or government request. A legal hold suspends all routine retention rules described above for the data in scope, until the hold is formally released.

Custodians notified of a legal hold must not delete, modify, or move covered data, including data on personal devices used for Acme work. Failure to preserve data under a legal hold may result in disciplinary action and exposes the company to spoliation sanctions.

Legal holds are reviewed every 90 days. When the underlying matter is resolved, Acme Legal releases the hold and routine retention resumes. Data preserved during the hold may then be deleted in accordance with the normal lifecycle described in sections 2 through 4.